University of Michigan
Winter 2026 Instructor Report
IOE 570 001 - STATS 570 001
Raed Al Kontar

50 out of 64 students responded to this evaluation.

Responses to University-wide questions about the course:

	SA	A	N	D	SD	N/A	Your Median	School/College Median	Univ-Wide Median
This course advanced my understanding of the subject matter. (Q1631)	37	10	2	0	0	1	4.8	4.4	4.5
My interest in the subject has increased because of this course. (Q1632)	33	13	3	0	0	1	4.8	4.2	4.2
I knew what was expected of me in this course.(Q1633)	36	11	2	0	0	1	4.8	4.4	4.6
I had a strong desire to take this course.(Q4)	21	21	7	0	0	1	4.3	4.0	4.0
As compared with other courses of equal credit, the workload for this course was (SA=Much Lighter, A=Lighter, N=Typical, D=Heavier, SD=Much Heavier). (Q891)	2	12	33	1	1	1	3.2	2.9	3.0

Responses to University-wide questions about the instructor:

	SA	A	N	D	SD	N/A	Your Median	School/College Median	Univ-Wide Median
Raed Al Kontar seemed well prepared for class meetings.(Q230)	43	3	2	0	0	1	4.9	4.7	4.8
Raed Al Kontar explained material clearly.(Q199)	41	7	1	0	0	1	4.9	4.6	4.7
Raed Al Kontar treated students with respect.(Q217)	44	4	1	0	0	1	4.9	4.8	4.8

Responses to questions about the course:

	SA	A	N	D	SD	N/A	Your Median
Overall, this was an excellent course. (Q1)	37	11	1	0	0	1	4.8
Examinations covered the important aspects of the course. (Q356)	39	9	1	0	0	1	4.9

Responses to questions about the instructor:

	SA	A	N	D	SD	N/A	Your Median
Overall, Raed Al Kontar was an excellent teacher. (Q2)	43	3	1	0	0	1	5.0
Raed Al Kontar stressed important points in lectures/discussions. (Q203)	43	4	1	0	0	1	4.9
Raed Al Kontar appeared to have a thorough knowledge of the subject. (Q207)	44	4	1	0	0	1	4.9
Raed Al Kontar acknowledged all questions insofar as possible. (Q216)	46	2	1	0	0	1	5.0
Raed Al Kontar encouraged constructive criticism. (Q218)	38	9	1	0	0	2	4.9

The medians are calculated from Winter 2026 data. University-wide medians are based on all UM classes in which an item was used. The school/college medians in this report are based on classes that are graduate level with enrollment of 16 to 74 in College of Engineering.

Written Comments

What are the major strengths of this class? What is helping you to learn? (Q979)

Comments
Great teaching team, lectures and notes were easily accessible and homeworks helped keep me on track with course material.
Excellent explanations of course material Focus on intuition rather than coding, especially when AI can do literally all of that Able to use AI, makes the course realistic as we need to know how to apply the intuition and techniques/where to use them, not how to physically code them anymore
I appreciated the in–class questions and examples, that helped me understand the lectures better and build some intuition about what's going on.
Lectures felt very clear and homework helped me learn the material further
Participation was encouraged. Helped me to learn what statistical methods are important for my research.
The information covered in this class is presented really well. Dr Al Kontar is very articulate, he uses an engaging tone and is clearly passionate about the topics he is presenting. The lectures have just enough content, sometimes some of the topics are harder and it might take a while for it to sink in but none of them ever feel stuffed with too many words/slides. He takes time to go over everything and doesn't rush through topics. I really appreciate how at the end of each topic he clearly states "here's what I want you to take away from all of this", I wish more professors did that, and I also appreciate how he spends a bit of time at the beginning of class recapping what's been discussed previously, it helps for those topics that are more challenging.
This class does well teaching the idea of a concept and then following up with application based material that is more helpful.
Raed's enthusiasm and passion for teaching this subject. His energy is infectious. He is able to explain concepts elegantly with varied examples.
I appreciated how this class began at the basics and gradually delved into more complex topics. It did not seem rushed, but a lot of material was able to be covered.
I appreciate how the professor balanced theory, intuition, and practical examples and used numerous diagrams and tables in the lecture material to help teach the material.
Prof. Al Kontar is a great lecturer. He shows genuine care for his students and welcomes questions of all levels. He is generous with his time and extremely understanding. The structure of the course homework and exams are very effective, particularly the aim to teach students the intuition behind what they are learning rather than rote learning of the equations and calculations.
Very clear course structure, I always know what the key take–home messages are. Sometimes, the lecture content is a bit math–heavy, but professor Read always stresses the key point of the lecture so that I'm very clear and feel confident about the course material.
The major strength of this class is the teacher. Raed was very good at teaching the intuition behind the class, and all of his lectures were fantastic. He really made a subject that I haven't spent much time in before enjoyable to learn.
The content itself is extremely useful and applicable to my research. The professor's openness and interest in the subject was also a good motivator.
– I understood everything deeply. – All materials were available online on Canvas. I could watch videos sometimes instead of attending all the sessions. I could watch videos multiple times and pause them to learn. This flexibility helps students to learn when they are not too tired and when they are focused.
The slides and notes are very clear and the teaching explains the points very well.

Please enter any additional comments you have for Raed Al Kontar. (Q981)

Comments
Thank you professor! This was a great course :)
I love the structure of the class. I wish we spent more time on BO and other advanced bayesian techniques. I also think that the BLR lecture was hard to follow.
I thoroughly enjoyed this class, and am planning to apply what I learned to my research!
great class
Very passionate and knowledgeable, wants us all to succeed
I took this course to round out an area of knowledge that I didn't have a lot of confidence/prior experience in, Dr. Al Kontar made a topic that wasn't really a passion of mine engaging and the way he conveyed all of the content so clearly motivated me to put the effort in on my end to really understand it, he was definitely one of the best professors I've had in my time here at Michigan. Thank you!
Always a great teacher. Made it easy to listen and understand his lectures because he speaks passionately and enthusiastically.
Great professor. Really loved having him as a class instructor. I am very interested to collaborate with Raed for research just because of his amazing character.
I really appreciated how Professor Al Kontar began every lecture with a recap of what we had learned the previous week. It really helped me to connect all the topics together, so I never felt lost during the lectures. I also appreciated how at the end of every lecture he pointed out the main highlights of what we had learned that day. Professor Al Kontar is a great lecturer and is very passionate about the material which made it very interesting learn about.
He is one of the best professors I've had at Michigan. All the teachers at U–M are great, but what sets Raed apart is how incredibly passionate he is about the material he teaches and how dedicated he is to teaching it to his students.
Great teacher, great course!
Prof. Al Kontar was fantastic. Anyone at Michigan would be fortunate to have him as a professor.
A fantastic teacher! Would love to take another class with him!
The professor is great at breaking down concepts and making it digestible using examples.
Thanks for the great class!
The whole course is well prepared and was taught in good pace. The lecture is very clear and enjoying. The professor is good at teaching, and also highly knowledgeable and passionate about the field.

How can Raed Al Kontar improve this class? If possible, give specific examples. (Q980)

Comments
Keep the homeworks! I think this class would have been much harder without having the homeworks to test my knowledge and keep me on track.
I would like to see more ways of how this is used in different fields!
Some of the homeworks were bunched a little too close together before the exam, so that made it a bit hard to finish everything and have enough time to study.
nothing
I think the class was very well done, the only critique I can think of at the moment (which for the most part was addressed in the second half of the course) was that having more than a week to complete the homeworks would be beneficial, considering how busy many of us are as grad students and how it takes some time for some of the content to really click.
Class was great! I would start assigning HWs a little bit earlier though.
I had difficulties initially in understanding the subject. Could have highlighted the pre requisites in the 1st class with the necessary resource because I had not studied all the pre reqs due to which I was blinking and not knowing a thing in the 1st few classes.
The class was excellent. One minor recommendation is to include more coding/application exercises in the homeworks. I felt that this was very helpful in understanding the material.
I think this had been mentioned before, but his hand writing is sometimes hard to understand.
I feel the last part on Bayesian regression and Bayesian optimization is a bit fast, and I understand the math concepts, but I still feel a bit unclear about what I can do with Bayesian optimization.
nothing its great
I suggest that there is a possibility to expand the syllabus further and include other concepts and lessons. For example, some project case studies, how we can define experiments for some specific goals in academic projects. Which parameters should we fix in each experiment?